

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

# BAD TIMING

First, the much-promised elections to the Congress Working Committee never materialised. Then came Rahul Gandhi's speeches in the UK alleging that Indian democracy was under threat, handing the prime minister and his party the excuse to play victim. Many a Congress leader thinks the party is ceding the narrative. Like when 'Naatu Naatu', the song from the film *RRR*, won an Oscar, and the party tweeted an image of the actors photoshopped with the faces of the PM and industrialist Gautam Adani. That very day Congress Rajasthan in-charge Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa exhorted Congress workers to "finish" Modi to get rid of Adani. Making the most of it, the BJP is crying foul and demanding an apology while the Congress seems on the back foot.

## NEVER TOO OLD



The warm welcome veteran Gujarat politician **Shankersinh Vaghela** gave Samajwadi Party chief **Akhilesh Yadav** at the wedding of his grandson has set rumour mills churning. Vaghela has in the past five years flirted with the BJP, NCP and even launched his own political front. The SP debuted in the Gujarat assembly with one MLA, Kandhal Jadeja, from Kutiyana in Porbandar. Now, it's looking to expand its footprint, and a face to front it. Is Vaghela the man?

## Wooing the Press

When West Bengal chief minister **Mamata Banerjee** and Leader of the Opposition Suvendu Adhikari are in the assembly, both are said to hold court with the journalists in attendance. In addition to the outreach and indulgence, the two friends-turned-foes also compete with each other in showering gifts on media persons. If Mamata distributes cakes and pastries from the best confectioner in town, Adhikari offers an assortment from another equally well-known patisserie. Imported chocolate brands, wallets and deodorants are also being gifted. And what could the leaders possibly be expecting in return? Just some good press.





## HOODWINK?

Maharashtra leader of the Opposition **Ajit Pawar** was giving mediapersons a few sound bites after the presentation of the budget in the assembly when his former boss Uddhav Thackeray walked into the press stands on the assembly premises. Pawar made way for Uddhav to face the media's booms, but gave a sly wink to someone standing on the side, the action captured on camera. CM Eknath Shinde and his band of rebels, who have long alleged that Pawar was giving Uddhav the short shrift, could well be saying: "We told you so."

## Have You Been ICED?

As several leaders of the Opposition parties across the country get grilled by the central agencies, a new acronym has come into existence—ICED. Used to define what they call harassment by BJP-led Union government, the I in the acronym stands for the Income Tax Department, C for the CBI and the last two letters for the Enforcement Directorate. The list of leaders who have been ICED is getting long. From Lalu Yadav in Bihar to K. Chandrashekar Rao in Telangana to Uddhav Thackeray in Maharashtra to Arvind Kejriwal in Delhi, all have felt cornered because of central agencies probing or arresting their party leaders.

*Kaushik Deka with Jumana Shah, Anilesh Mahajan, Romita Datta and Dhaval Kulkarni*